people. The relief when I got off the mark to the seventh ball I faced, with a push for three, was immediate and intense.

Posterity will record that was the shot that took me to 1,000 Test runs at the Oval. My attention was seized by the flock of pigeons, pecking away at the outfield. They serve no useful purpose, other than to interfere with the grind of concentration and accumulation. A top footballer like Harry Kane can have a poor opening twenty minutes and still have time to excel. If I do the same, I'm back in the pavilion, more often than not.

Moeen Ali had told me, earlier in the week, that it was written that I would get a hundred. He was one innings out, yet I began to believe him when I was dropped in the gully soon after lunch, when I had made 37. Mystic Mo's certainty about my destiny grew with our partnership; his confidence made me smile when I brought my 50 up.

Athletes are taught to prioritize process over outcome, but once I passed 60 the prospect of a century became real. 'Shit, I might be able to do this,' I thought. Mistake. I dragged the ball on, an inside edge into the middle stump from a decent-length delivery that didn't bounce as much as I expected, and was dismissed for 71.

The gift horse had bolted. I was annoyed but made a conscious effort to register and respond to the applause, because it could have been the last walk back with an innings of substance behind me. The chances of successive half-centuries weren't great. Once we had dismissed India for 292, and I had ten minutes to prepare for my 291st, and final, Test innings, I tried to take it all in. Time passed surprisingly slowly. When I emerged on the balcony, I noticed everyone in the crowd had turned to face me.

Forty minutes' play remained before tea when I walked to the crease. I didn't want this to be the last day I batted for England, since a large group of family and friends were coming to watch me the following morning. I knew they'd be following my progress on TV, or on their phones. No pressure, Chef. I had a simple mental mantra: 'Don't make this the last ball.' It is amazing what you can train your brain to do.

Batting is so instinctive, and you have so little time to react, that movements become automatic. Thoughts might flash through your mind – 'Get forward', 'Don't play a cover shot', '*Do* play a cover shot', 'Don't pull this one, leave it' – but I tended to rely on trigger words or phrases to aid my concentration. On this endless afternoon, I followed principles I had discussed with Bawds years before.